

Word family: **little / less / least / littler / littlest**

Base word: little

Part of speech: mainly **adjective, determiner, pronoun, and adverb**

Comparative / superlative:

* for **amount**: **little → less → least**

* for **physical size / informal descriptive use**: **little → littler → littlest** can occur, but **smaller / smallest** is often more natural

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **a little**

* **little time / little money**

* **a little time / a little money**

* **little by little**

* **a little bit**

* **little more than**

* **little did I know**

* **little wonder**

* **a little adventure**

* **a little child**

* **the little one**

* **little things**

* **little chance / little hope**

* **in little time**

* **not a little** **(formal)**

Meaning in this passage

> Adults often get trapped in routine, whereas children like Leo can turn an ordinary afternoon into a **little adventure**.

Here, **little** means:

small in scale, modest, not very large or serious — 小小的；小型的

The speaker does **not** mean “very little adventure” or “almost no adventure.”

Instead:

a little adventure = 一場小小的冒險；一個規模不大的有趣經歷

****中文翻譯：****

成年人往往容易陷入一成不變的日常生活，而像 Leo 這樣的孩子，卻可以把一個普通的下午變成一場****小小的冒險****。

So in this passage, ****little**** is a ****positive size/intensity modifier****, not the quantity determiner ****little = 很少、幾乎沒有****.

1. ****little (體積小 / 規模小) — 小的 ; 小小的****

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> Children like Leo can turn an ordinary afternoon into a ****little adventure****.

像 Leo 這樣的孩子，可以把一個普通的下午變成一場****小小的冒險****。

Practice 2

> They live in a ****little house**** by the sea.

他們住在海邊一間****小房子****裏。

Practice 3

> She gave me a ****little smile****.

她向我露出一個****淺淺的小微笑****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little = 體積、規模或程度較小的****

2. ****little child / little boy / little girl — 年紀小的 ; 幼小的****

Here ****little**** often means ****young and small****, especially affectionately.

Practice 1

> The ****little boy**** was holding his mother's hand.

那個****小男孩****牽着媽媽的手。

Practice 2

> She looked after her **little sister**.

她照顧自己的**小妹妹**。

MCQ-ready definition:

little + child/person = 年紀較小、幼小的

3. **little one** — 小孩；小傢伙

Often affectionate.

Practice 1

> The **little one** is already asleep.

那個**小傢伙 / 小孩**已經睡着了。

Practice 2

> Keep an eye on the **little ones** near the pool.

在泳池附近要照看好那些**小孩子**。

MCQ-ready definition:

little one = 對小孩或年幼者的親切稱呼

4. **little things** — 小事；細小事物

Practice 1

> It's the **little things** that make a home feel warm.

往往是那些**小事**令一個家感到溫暖。

Practice 2

> She notices the **little things** that other people miss.

她會留意到別人忽略的**細節小事**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little things = 規模不大但可能有意義的小事或細節****

5. ****little (很少 ; 幾乎沒有) — 幾乎沒有 ; 很少****

This is a major and very different use.

It is used with ****uncountable nouns****.

Practice 1

> We have ****little time**** left.

我們剩下的時間****很少****。

Practice 2

> There is ****little hope**** of success.

成功的希望****很渺茫 / 幾乎沒有****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little + uncountable noun = 數量很少 , 少到接近不足或沒有****

6. ****a little (有一點 ; 少量) — 一點 ; 少量****

Very important contrast with plain ****little****.

Practice 1

> We still have ****a little time****.

我們還有****一點時間****。

Practice 2

> Add ****a little sugar****.

加****一點糖****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a little + uncountable noun = 有少量某物，雖然不多，但仍然有****

Important distinction 1: ****little vs a little****

This is one of the most important contrasts.

****little****

negative or near-negative:

> I have ****little money****.

我****幾乎沒甚麼錢****。

****a little****

positive:

> I have ****a little money****.

我****有一點錢****。

So:

* ****little**** = 很少，少得不夠

* ****a little**** = 有一點，雖少但有

7. ****little chance / little possibility — 機會很小****

Practice 1

> There is ****little chance**** of rain today.

今天下雨的****機會****很小。

Practice 2

> We have ****little possibility**** of finishing on time.

我們準時完成的可能性****很低****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little + chance/possibility = 機會或可能性非常低****

8. ****little interest / little attention — 幾乎沒有興趣 / 注意****

Practice 1

> He showed ****little interest**** in the discussion.

他對討論****幾乎沒有興趣****。

Practice 2

> The issue received ****little attention****.

這個問題****幾乎沒有得到關注****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little + abstract uncountable noun = 某種程度、關注或興趣非常少****

9. ****a little + adjective/adverb — 有點；稍微****

Here ****a little**** modifies degree.

Practice 1

> I'm ****a little tired****.

我****有點累****。

Practice 2

> Could you speak ****a little more slowly****?

你可以說得****稍微慢一點****嗎？

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a little + adjective/adverb = 程度上稍微、有點****

10. ****a little bit — 一點點；有一點****

Informal and very common.

Practice 1

> I'm **a little bit nervous**.

我**有一點緊張**。

Practice 2

> Move it **a little bit** to the left.

把它向左移**一點點**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a little bit = 少量、稍微，語氣通常較口語****

11. ****little by little — 一點一點地；逐漸地****

Practice 1

> ****Little by little****, his confidence returned.

他的自信**一點一點地恢復了**。

Practice 2

> The town changed ****little by little****.

那個城鎮**逐漸地**改變了。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little by little = 以很小的步驟逐漸發生****

12. ****little more than — 只不過；僅僅比……多一點****

Practice 1

> The room was ****little more than a box****.

那個房間**簡直就像一個盒子一樣小**。

Practice 2

> He was **little more than a child** when he started working.

他開始工作時**幾乎還只是個孩子**。

MCQ-ready definition:

little more than X = 幾乎只是 X ; 並沒有比 X 多多少

13. **little less than — 幾乎等於 ; 只差一點**

Less common, but useful.

Practice 1

> The journey took **little less than three hours**.

旅程用了**接近三小時**。

Practice 2

> The project cost **little less than a million dollars**.

這個項目花了**接近一百萬美元**。

MCQ-ready definition:

little less than X = 比 X 少一點點 , 接近 X

14. **little did I know... — 我當時完全不知道.....**

A fixed inverted structure, often narrative.

Practice 1

> **Little did I know** that the decision would change my life.

我當時**完全不知道**那個決定會改變我的人生。

Practice 2

> **Little did she know** what was waiting for her.

她當時**完全不知道**有甚麼在等着她。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little did someone know... = 某人當時幾乎完全不知道後來會發生的事****

15. ****little wonder — 難怪****

Usually in the expression:

**It's little wonder that...**

Practice 1

> It's ****little wonder**** that he was tired after working all night.

他整晚工作後感到疲累，****難怪如此****。

Practice 2

> ****Little wonder**** she was upset.

她不開心，****一點也不奇怪****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little wonder = 某個結果很合理，因此不足為奇****

16. ****in little time — 在很短時間內****

Practice 1

> She learned the system in ****little time****.

她在****很短時間內****學會了這個系統。

Practice 2

> The problem was solved in ****very little time****.

問題在****很短時間內****就解決了。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little time = 很短的時間量****

17. **little room / little space — 空間很少**

Practice 1

> There is **little room** for error.

幾乎**沒有出錯的空間**。

Practice 2

> The apartment has **very little storage space**.

這個單位的儲物空間**非常少**。

MCQ-ready definition:

little room/space = 可用空間很少；引申也可指餘地不足

18. **little room for X (figurative) — 幾乎沒有餘地**

Practice 1

> The schedule leaves **little room for delay**.

這個時間表幾乎**沒有延誤的餘地**。

Practice 2

> The rules leave **little room for interpretation**.

這些規則幾乎**沒有解讀上的彈性**。

MCQ-ready definition:

little room for X = 幾乎沒有足夠空間、自由或餘地讓 X 發生

19. **with little difficulty / effort — 幾乎不費力地**

Practice 1

> She completed the task with **little difficulty**.

她幾乎**沒甚麼困難**就完成了工作。

Practice 2

> He lifted the box with **little effort**.

他**沒花多少力氣**便把箱子提起來。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****with little + noun = 某種困難、努力、阻礙等程度很低****

20. **little if any — 即使有也很少；幾乎沒有**

More formal.

Practice 1

> The change had **little, if any, effect**.

這項改變**即使有影響，也非常少**。

Practice 2

> There is **little, if any, evidence** to support the claim.

幾乎**沒有甚麼證據**支持這項說法。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little, if any = 數量極少，甚至可能完全沒有****

21. **not a little — 非常；相當**

Formal/literary, and easy to misunderstand.

Practice 1

> She was **not a little surprised**.

她**非常驚訝**。

Practice 2

> The news caused **not a little concern**.

這個消息引起了**相當大的憂慮**。

MCQ-ready definition:

not a little = 相當多；非常

This is a formal understatement pattern.

22. **little** (adverb : 不多；幾乎不) — 很少地；幾乎不

Practice 1

> He **little understood** how serious the problem was.

他當時**幾乎不明白**問題有多嚴重。

Practice 2

> She **little expected** to see him there.

她**完全沒料到**會在那裏見到他。

MCQ-ready definition:

little + verb = 某種知道、預期、理解等程度非常低

Register: often formal/literary.

23. **the little I have / know** — 我僅有的 / 我所知不多的

Practice 1

> I'll share **the little I have**.

我會把自己**僅有的一點東西**分享出來。

Practice 2

> From **the little I know**, the plan seems reasonable.

根據我**所知不多的資料**，這個計劃似乎合理。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****the little + clause = 雖然數量不多，但指那全部少量內容****

24. ****little by comparison — 相比之下很少 / 很小****

Practice 1

> Our costs are ****little by comparison****.

相比之下，我們的成本****很低****。

Practice 2

> The first problem seems ****little by comparison****.

相比之下，第一個問題顯得****微不足道****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****little by comparison = 與另一事物相比，數量、規模或重要性很小****

25. ****littler / littlest — 更小的 / 最小的****

These forms are possible, especially when talking affectionately about children or concrete size, but often ****smaller / smallest**** is more natural.

Practice 1

> When I was ****littler****, I was afraid of dogs.

我****更小的時候****很怕狗。

Practice 2

> She's the ****littlest**** child in the family.

她是家裏****年紀最小 / 個子最小的孩子****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****littler/littlest = 在年齡或大小上更小 / 最小；較口語****

Important distinction 1: **little vs small**

They overlap, but not completely.

small

neutral objective size

> a **small house**

一間小房子

little

often sounds:

- * more personal
- * affectionate
- * expressive
- * less purely technical

> a **little house**

一間小巧的房子

In your sentence:

> a **little adventure**

sounds warm, playful, and modest.

A small adventure is possible, but less natural and less charming.

Important distinction 2: **little = small vs little = not much**

These are two major branches.

Size

> a **little adventure**

小小的冒險

Quantity

> **little time**

幾乎沒有時間

The noun type often tells you which meaning applies.

Important distinction 3: **little vs few**

little

with **uncountable nouns**

> little time

> little money

> little hope

few

with **countable plural nouns**

> few people

> few chances

> few ideas

So:

>  little people

if you mean “not many people”

Use:

>  few people

Though **little people** can literally mean small people/children depending on context.

Important distinction 4: **a little vs a few**

a little

uncountable:

> a little water

一點水

a few

countable plural:

> a few books

幾本書

Important distinction 5: **less vs fewer**

Because **little → less → least** applies mainly to uncountable amount:

> less time

> less money

Traditional formal grammar often prefers:

> fewer people

> fewer mistakes

for countable nouns.

Important distinction 6: **little vs less**

little

base quantity:

> We have **little time**.

我們幾乎沒有時間。

less

comparative:

> We have **less time** than yesterday.

我們比昨天有**更少時間**。

Important distinction 7: **little vs least**

least

superlative amount:

> This option requires the **least effort**.

這個選項需要**最少努力**。

So:

little → less → least

for amount.

Important distinction 8: **little child vs small child**

Both are correct.

small child

more objective: physically/chronologically small.

little child

often warmer or more affectionate.

This emotional colouring is one reason **little** appears so often in storytelling.

Important distinction 9: **a little adventure vs little adventure**

This is crucial.

a little adventure

= 一場**小小的冒險**

Here **little** is an adjective modifying **adventure**.

little adventure

without an article, in another context, could suggest **very little adventure/adventurousness**.

For example:

> There was **little adventure** in his life.

他的生活中**幾乎沒有冒險**。

So the grammar changes the meaning dramatically.

Important distinction 10: **little room = two meanings**

Literal quantity

> There is **little room** in the car.

車內**空間很少**。

Figurative

> There is **little room for error**.

幾乎沒有犯錯的餘地。

Same quantity idea, extended metaphorically.

Important distinction 11: **little did I know — inversion**

The normal order:

> I knew little about what would happen.

But the fixed narrative structure is:

> **Little did I know** what would happen.

When **little** is fronted for emphasis, auxiliary inversion occurs:

* **Little** did I know...

* **Little** did she realize...

* **Little** did they expect...

This is formal/literary and especially common in storytelling.

Important distinction 12: **little** adventure vs minor adventure

little adventure

warm, playful, modest in scale.

minor adventure

sounds more analytical and emphasizes limited importance.

For your Leo passage, **little** adventure is much more natural because it captures childlike imagination.

Family-extension note

Little is a very strong grammar-and-polysemy word because it has two major semantic systems:

1. **small size / young age / modest scale**

* little house

* little child

* little adventure

* little things

2. **small amount / almost none**

* little time

* little money

* little hope

* little interest

From the second branch come important contrasts:

* **little** = hardly any

* **a little** = some

And several fixed structures:

* little by little

* little did I know

* little wonder

* little more than

So this is a word where **articles and grammar can completely change the interpretation**, even though the spelling stays the same.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea
-----	-----	-----
little adventure	小小的冒險	small scale
little house	小房子	small size
little child	小孩；幼小的	young/small
little one	小孩；小傢伙	affectionate reference
little things	小事；細節	small matters
little time	幾乎沒有時間	very small amount
little money	幾乎沒錢	hardly any
a little time	一點時間	some, though not much
a little tired	有點累	slight degree
a little bit	一點點	small degree
little by little	一點一點地	gradually
little chance	機會很小	low probability
little room for X	幾乎沒有 X 的餘地	little flexibility
little more than X	幾乎只是 X	barely more
little did I know	我當時完全不知道	hardly knew
little wonder	難怪	unsurprising
little, if any	幾乎沒有	possibly none
not a little	非常；相當	formal emphatic amount
the little I know	我所知不多的內容	all of a small amount
littler/littlest	更小 / 最小	size/age comparison
less	更少	comparative amount
least	最少	superlative amount

For your original sentence

> Adults often get trapped in routine, whereas children like Leo can turn an ordinary afternoon into a **little adventure**.

Here:

little = 小小的；規模不大的，但有趣而特別的

It does **not** mean:

> very little adventure

> 幾乎沒有冒險 ❌

Instead:

> **a little adventure**

> = **一場小小的冒險**

The word adds a warm, playful tone. Leo does not need a dramatic expedition to make life interesting—his imagination can make an ordinary afternoon feel like **a small adventure of its own**.